



Introduction to business data request

Welcome, future data pro!

Thanks for joining me for this investigation into business data requests.

The business data request is the kickoff to help launch a successful project.

It's where all the fun starts!

A business data request is any business question that can be answered with data.

Whether the request involves data that already exists, or new data.

As a data analyst, you'll typically receive this request through a ticketing system.

This is a tool for recording requests and assigning them to the appropriate team member.

Data requests can be simple or complex.

Some can be responded to by a single data analyst.

Others will require a team of data analysts to work together to generate a larger report.

Typically, data requests will vary from organization to organization, but data requests will have some similar elements.

First, requests can be internal, from employees within the organization, or external, from outside.

External requests may come from government or regulatory agencies, vendors, users, or clients.

Types of requests might include answers to a data-related question or the creation of a data report, an extract, or a dashboard.

And requests usually include information or structure specifics.

Here's a case to consider.

Drew, a data analyst, works for a company that runs clinical trials for a health care product.

Stakeholders want to know how long participants spend filling out surveys during the trial.

So, Drew receives a business data request asking for a report about survey timing.

This is an internal request for a data report.

Drew can also potentially add the report information to a dashboard.

As Drew begins to work on this request, there are several things he keeps in mind.

First, the overarching goal.

In this case, the goal is to find out how much time participants are spending on surveys.

And, it's also a great practice to go beyond this and try to understand why the stakeholders need the data.

An example question Drew might ask about the goal is: Do the stakeholders need to correlate the length of time taken with the quality of the response?

Then, Drew will determine what's being measured.

In this case, it's pretty straightforward — the length of time participants take to finish a survey.

Next, Drew figures out what data is needed and how much.

Does he consider all survey responses times?

Or, only the surveys that launched in the last year?

In this case, he determines he wants all surveys, but segmented by survey name.

Drew reviews the survey completions to identify any errors or outliers in the data.

For example, if the average survey completion time was 10 minutes and a participant took 24 hours, is that a bug or did they actually take that long?

Finally, Drew searches for trends to identify, within the survey name segment.

For example, does one particular survey take longer than the rest?

Next, he gathers the data and creates a summary report of all the information.

This enables Drew to find connections and draw conclusions about how long participants spent filling out surveys during the trial engagement.

This is just one example of a data request, and you're sure to come across lots more throughout your data career.